Decision, Task, Prerequisite, Owner

The planning words in your husband's care, and what to write down for each.

Working out what comes next has its own vocabulary: decision, task, prerequisite, owner. Here are eighteen of the words in one plain line each, with what to jot down when one comes up.

The planning words are the Family Care Roadmap's own, put plainly. A line with a number beside it follows the public source listed at the end. None of it is for sizing up your husband's situation yourself.

Kinds of item

Decision

A choice somebody has to make, such as what answer to give the rehab.

WRITE DOWN The choice in one line, and whose it is to make.

Task

Something somebody has to do, such as picking up a prescription or returning a call.

WRITE DOWN The task, and the person who has agreed to do it, if anyone has.

Open question

Something nobody in the family knows yet. Medicare's discharge checklist tells caregivers to write their questions down and discuss them with the staff. [1]

WRITE DOWN The question, word for word, and who could answer it.

Professional-review item

A question or decision that belongs to a professional and not to the family: his doctor or nurse, the pharmacist, the social worker or your care consultant.

WRITE DOWN Whose it is, who in the family will ask, and what they said.

Order

Confirmed date

A date somebody gave you, as opposed to one the family has been assuming.

WRITE DOWN The date, who gave it, and the day they told you.

Prerequisite

Something that has to be settled before a decision can be made.

WRITE DOWN What it is, and whether it's settled, open or not known.

Dependency

One item that has to wait for another.

WRITE DOWN The pair together: the one that waits, and the one it waits on.

Monitoring

Keeping an eye on something and noting what you see, as opposed to acting on it now.

WRITE DOWN What you're watching and what you saw, with the day. What it means is for the professional it belongs to.

Review date

A day the family agrees to look at an item again. For a care plan as a whole, the CDC suggests an update every year, or more often if the person has a change in health or medicines. [2]

WRITE DOWN The date, and who agreed to it.

People

Owner

The person who has agreed to do a task. The Family Caregiver Alliance says to make sure each person understands what he or she has agreed to do. [3]

WRITE DOWN Their name, once they've said yes and not before.

Backup

A second person who can step in on an important task if the owner can't.

WRITE DOWN Their name, and that they know they're the backup.

Lead caregiver

The family member doing most of the day-to-day caring. MedlinePlus describes a caregiver as someone who gives care to a person who needs help taking care of themselves, and says informal caregivers are usually family members or friends. [4]

WRITE DOWN Your own name, what you do now, and what you can't take on.

Point person

Someone who keeps the process moving and makes sure people understand what's been decided. AARP's planning chart has a point-person column beside each area of need. [5]

WRITE DOWN Who it is for each area. It needn't be the same person every time.

Discharge planner

The hospital's point person for planning the discharge. Some hospitals have a dedicated one; it may also be a social worker, a nurse or another hospital representative. [6]

WRITE DOWN Their name and direct number, and what they've asked you for.

Care manager (case manager)

A professional, usually with a background in counseling, social work or a related healthcare field, trained to assess a person's situation and to implement and monitor a care plan. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether one is involved, and their name and number.

On paper

Goal

What a step is meant to bring about. AARP's guide says every family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care. [5]

WRITE DOWN What your husband says he wants, in his words, kept separate from what the family wants.

Care plan

In the CDC's words, a form where you can summarize a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether he has one, who wrote it, and its date.

Completion evidence

Whatever shows that a task was done: a confirmation, a name, a date.

WRITE DOWN What you were told or given when it was finished, and by whom.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say which decision comes first, who should own what, or what your husband needs. Those are worked out with the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You know what the planning words mean and what to jot down for each. The care interview supplies what the words get applied to: it walks you through your husband's situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine, NIH), Caregiver Health
5. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.